The Verdant Embrace

A Side Quest for 4–5 Characters of Levels 4–6

A one-session horror adventure of false comfort, body horror, and impossible mercy.

Adventure Overview

The Verdant Embrace is a self-contained side quest built around themes of infection, sedation, and mercy. The characters encounter a hooded druid in distress and are drawn — willingly or otherwise — toward a hidden grove deep in the wood. The grove does not lie to them. It simply makes them stop caring about the truth. The druid at its centre is no longer a man. He is a vessel, and he wants the characters to become the same.

There is no cure. There is no rescue. There is only the choice of how it ends.

A Wayside Adventure

This adventure is designed to be encountered *in passing* — not sought out. It works best when the characters are already on their way somewhere else: between cities, cutting through a forest, or making camp for the night. The hook requires no prior setup and no quest board. It simply happens, the way bad things in forests simply happen.

Drop this encounter in the moment travel starts to feel routine. The characters should not feel like they walked into a dungeon. They should feel like the dungeon walked into them.

Adventure at a Glance

- **Tier:** 1–2 (Levels 4–6, party of 4–5)
- **Estimated Play Time:** 3–5 hours
- **Setting:** Any forested wilderness region — no prior setup required
- **Best used as:** An unplanned encounter during overland travel
- **Tone:** Psychological horror, body horror, tragedy
- **Themes:** Infection, false comfort, loss of self, mercy killing
- **New Creatures:** Infected Druid, Fungal Wolf, Fungal Deer, Fungal Bear, Spore-Touched Wanderer
- **System:** D&D 5th Edition (SRD 5.1, OGL)

Background

Aldric Mourne spent forty years as a member of a Circle of Spores — a druidic order that venerates death not as an ending but as transformation, and that practices communion with fungal networks as a form of communion with the forest's deeper memory. He was a respected elder. A careful scholar. A man who wrote extensively on the relationship between mycelia, decay, and what he called *the quiet continuity* — the idea that nothing in nature is ever truly lost, only broken down and passed on.

He was, for most of his life, right.

The problem began with age. Not fear of it, exactly — but curiosity. The mycelial networks he communed with were ancient. Some threads in the bog beneath his grove were centuries old, still carrying the chemical memory of trees that had fallen before his great-grandparents were born. Aldric began to wonder: if the network remembered, could it *preserve*? Could a mind, suffused deeply enough into the mycelium, persist beyond the body that housed it?

He began experimenting on himself. Slowly, methodically, the way he did everything.

The Circle noticed the changes and warned him. He thanked them and continued. The warnings became interventions. He left the Circle rather than stop.

By the time anyone thought to look for him, he had been alone in the bog for two years. What they would have found, had they gone — and they did not — was not a man who had made a mistake. It was a man who believed, with complete sincerity, that he had succeeded.

The mycelium did not consume Aldric Mourne. He invited it in, degree by degree, layer by layer, until the boundary between himself and the network became academic. His body continues. His memories continue. Whether *he* continues is a question the text cannot answer — and neither can he.

Circle of Spores — Context for DMs

What Is the Circle of Spores?

The Circle of Spores is a druidic subclass (introduced in *Tasha's Cauldron of Everything*) that views fungi, rot, and death as sacred parts of the natural cycle. Members commune with mycelial networks, animate dead matter with spore-energy, and believe that decay is as holy as growth.

Aldric represents an extreme end of a genuine philosophical tradition. His beliefs are not wrong — they are simply taken further than they were ever meant to go. This makes him more unsettling than a simple cultist: everything he says about the forest, about continuity, about the beauty of decomposition, is something a living Circle of Spores druid might also say.

For players who recognise the subclass: This is intentional. The adventure works better if the philosophy feels familiar.

The Fungal Spore Effect

The grove exhales a near-invisible cloud of spores. Any creature that spends more than a minute within 300 feet of the grove's centre must make a **DC 13 Wisdom saving throw**. On a failure, the creature is affected by the **Verdant Embrace**.

Verdant Embrace (Spore Sedation)

The spores do not distort what the creature sees. They distort what it *feels* about what it sees.

An affected creature can perceive the rot, the pale growth, the half-buried figures — but none of it triggers alarm. Threatening things feel distant and unimportant. Aldric's ruined face registers as unusual, not horrifying. The creature finds itself inclined to agree, to stay, to listen a little longer.

Mechanical effects while under the Verdant Embrace:

- Disadvantage on Insight checks and Wisdom saving throws
- Cannot willingly leave the grove without first succeeding on a DC 13 Wisdom saving throw (action)
- Advantage on all Charisma checks made *against* the affected creature
- The creature does not feel urgency. It does not feel afraid.

Duration: Until the creature takes damage, moves more than 300 feet from the grove's centre, or succeeds on a DC 13 Wisdom saving throw at the end of each hour.

DM Note: Affected characters still perceive everything correctly — they just *don't react to it properly*. A player might describe their character noticing the buried hand beneath the roots and simply... not mentioning it to the others. Encourage this. The horror is that they see the truth and it doesn't feel like it matters.

Act I — The Hooded Man

The adventure begins on a forest road — or what passes for one here. The path cuts through terrain that can't quite decide what it is: old woodland on one side, bog on the other, the boundary between them soft and unreliable. The trees are dark-barked alder and ancient willow, their roots half-submerged. The ground beside the path is spongy, and in places it shifts underfoot without warning. Somewhere to the left, water stands black and still between the trunks.

It smells of peat and wet bark and something faintly sweet — not unpleasant, just present, the way a smell is present when it has been there so long the forest has stopped noticing it.

Scene 1: Out of the Trees

The first sign of trouble is sound — something crashing through undergrowth at speed, getting closer. Then the hooded figure bursts onto the road directly in front of the characters.

> He comes out of the treeline at a dead run — an old man in a grey-green cloak, hood pulled forward so far you can barely see the lower half of his face, arms pumping. He nearly collides with you.
>
> *"Please —"* he gasps, grabbing the nearest of you by the arm. His grip is stronger than it should be. *"Please, help me — it's been following me since the creek, I don't know why, it's never —"*
>
> The undergrowth behind him explodes.

An owlbear tears onto the road — enormous, moving with the single-minded momentum of something that has been chasing prey for a long time and is nearly done being patient. It fixes its glazed amber eyes on Aldric.

DM Note: The Owlbear Encounter

The owlbear is in an early stage of mycelial colonisation. Aldric's presence disturbs it: the network recognises him as its own, but the owlbear's nervous system hasn't fully accepted the signal yet. It is confused, and afraid.

Combat: The owlbear focuses on Aldric on its first turn. If a character deals 10+ damage in a single hit, it shifts aggression to that character. It fights until reduced to 30 hp, then disengages and retreats.

Examination (dead or fled): DC 12 Medicine or Nature — pale mycelial threads trace the skin behind its ears and down its neck, running into the muscle.

Aldric during combat: He stands to the side, murmuring quietly — as if trying to soothe the owlbear from a distance. He seems more distressed by its distress than by the danger to himself.

Scene 2: After the Fight

Once the owlbear retreats or is killed, Aldric exhales slowly. His calm is immediate and wrong — a man who just ran for his life should be winded. He is not.

> *"Thank you."* His voice has settled. Whatever panic was in it is gone now, replaced by something warmer — and oddly unhurried for a man who was just running for his life.
>
> He tilts his head, studying each of you in turn. You cannot see his eyes under the hood, but you have the distinct impression of being assessed — not with suspicion, but with genuine curiosity.
>
> *"I don't suppose,"* he says carefully, *"you'd be willing to walk with me a little further. My home isn't far. And I find I would enjoy the company."*

Aldric will speak with the characters as they walk. He is calm, warm, and seems genuinely grateful.

- **If asked why the owlbear was chasing him:** He seems genuinely confused — and briefly, almost lucidly troubled. He has known that animal for years. It has never reacted to him that way before. He trails off mid-sentence, then redirects with a warmth that arrives a beat too quickly.
- **If asked about his hood:** He says he had an accident. That he was working with concentrated spore cultures and misjudged the exposure. He says it doesn't hurt. He says the forest has been *correcting* the damage — his word, *correcting* — and that it's further along than it looks.
- **If asked about the Circle:** He speaks of them with something that might be fondness, might be pity. *"They study the threshold but they're afraid to cross it. I understand that. I was too, for a long time."*
- **If asked about death or aging:** His one visible eye brightens. *"Everything the Circle teaches is true. Nothing is lost. The network remembers. I just wanted to know if it could remember* me."*
- **If asked what he wants:** He pauses. *"I've been alone out here for a long time. I wanted to share what I found. That's all it ever was."*

Skill Checks: Reading Aldric

DC 12 Insight: His calm is wrong. His relief reads as performed, a beat too slow.

DC 13 Perception: A faint smell drifts from beneath his hood — like bread left too long in a damp cellar.

DC 15 Medicine: His breathing is unusual. He does not pause between breaths — a long, continuous cycle, like a sleeping animal. For a man who just ran through the forest, he is not winded at all.

Act II — The Grove

Aldric leads the characters off the path and into the trees. There is no trail — he navigates by something else, some internal orientation that doesn't require landmarks. The ground grows softer with every minute. After a while the characters are moving along narrow ridges of solid earth between stretches of black water, stepping over exposed roots that plunge into the bog like fingers. Mist sits low between the trunks. The birdsong that followed them from the road stops.

The light here is green-grey, filtered through canopies layered with moss and something paler — shelf fungi in whites and yellows, bracket growths the colour of old bone. The smell that was faintly sweet on the road is stronger now: earthy, damp, with an undertone that isn't quite rot and isn't quite bread and isn't quite anything the characters have smelled before.

They walk for perhaps half an hour before the trees open.

The grove is a raised island in the bog — perhaps sixty feet across, the ground drier here than anywhere they've passed through, the earth dark and spongy beneath a crust of pale growth. An ancient tree stands at the centre, enormous and perfectly still. Its bark is entirely consumed by a pale, ridged mycelium that has spread outward across the ground in thin white threads, visible where the moss hasn't covered them.

The bog surrounds it on three sides. On the fourth, a low wooden structure — more accumulation than construction — leans against a cluster of alders. Shelves of bracket fungi cover the roof. Smoke rises from somewhere inside, slow and grey.

Between the roots of the central tree, the ground is uneven. A shape protrudes — the curve of a shoulder, perhaps, or a knee. It is hard to tell.

Two wolves stand at the treeline. Their coats are grey, but pale threads run beneath the fur along their spines. They do not growl. They watch.

The air is very quiet.

Aldric spreads his arms. *"Home,"* he says.

For characters under the Verdant Embrace: They register all of the above. The ground, the shapes, the wolves, the smell. It simply doesn't feel like a problem. Something at the back of the mind says: *this is fine. This is a place of rest.*

For characters who resisted: Read the above as written, and let the silence do its work.

Exploring the Grove

The Hut

The structure against the alders is Aldric's home — or was. The interior is still recognisably a druid's dwelling: dried herbs hanging from the rafters, a cot in the corner, shelves of stoppered vials, a hearth with a slow fire and a pot above it that contains something dark and fibrous. His journals are here, stacked on a low table beside a stool. The most recent entries are methodical research notes — experiments, observations, dosages — written in a hand that grows more difficult to read with each page, the letters slowly losing their spacing and eventually running together in long, unbroken lines.

DC 13 Investigation (journals): The early entries describe Circle of Spores theory. The middle entries record self-experimentation with increasing urgency. The final legible entry reads: *"The boundary is dissolving. I am not afraid. I am not anything. I am still here. I think."*

The Half-Buried Figures

At least three figures are partially visible between the roots of the central tree. A **DC 12 Investigation** check reveals one is recent — within the last few months. A **DC 14 Medicine** check reveals faint pulses and slow, rhythmic breathing that does not match the rise and fall of a sleeping chest. They cannot be woken. They cannot be freed without killing them.

The Central Tree

The tree is dead. A **DC 15 Nature** check confirms it has been dead for at least a decade — but the mycelial network within its trunk and roots holds it perfectly upright. The pale threads spread from its roots across the entire grove and continue into the bog in every direction. This is not a tree with a fungus. This is a fungus that has kept a tree's body as a home.

The Fungal Wolves

The two wolves move quietly around the edges of the grove. They do not approach the characters unless Aldric is threatened. They have been with him for three years — he calls them by name (*Mire* and *Pale*), and they respond to his voice the way dogs respond to a beloved owner, which is the most unsettling thing about them.

If a character attempts to pet or approach them: they allow it, but their eyes are glassy and the mycelial threads are visible beneath the skin around their muzzles if anyone looks closely (DC 11 Perception).

Aldric Without His Hood

At some point during the grove sequence, Aldric removes his hood — either because the characters ask directly, or because he does so himself when he senses they are beginning to understand.

He reaches up, and pushes back the hood.

The right side of his face is the face of an old man — weathered, kind-eyed, human. The left side is gone. Not wounded. *Gone.* Where bone and skin should be, there is a ridged mass of pale fungal growth, the texture of cauliflower, studded with small dark clusters that pulse faintly. The growth extends from his temple down to his jaw, and the eye socket on that side is sealed — filled in by something that glistens.

He smiles with half a face. *"I know how it looks,"* he says, gently. *"But I don't feel any pain. I haven't, in years. Don't you want that?"*

Roleplaying Aldric

Aldric is not a monster. He is a tragedy. He will not threaten them directly. He will ask, invite, and describe. If pushed, he becomes sad rather than angry.

Unscripted moments — use these naturally, without prompting:

- He stops beside a particular tree, places his palm flat against the bark, and says its name quietly. Not a species. A name.
- He mentions his dog — *"Birch would have liked you"* — then pauses, as if something briefly confused him. He moves on without elaborating.
- If a character laughs at something, his reaction is half a second too slow. Then he smiles, warmly and completely.
- When describing the grove, he says *"we"* without noticing. He never corrects himself.
- Near the central tree, he touches one of the half-buried shapes gently, the way you'd touch a sleeping child. *"They're dreaming,"* he says. *"Quite happily, I think."*

Act III — What Cannot Be Undone

The Break

For a moment, he is simply still.

"I can't let you go." The warmth is still there. He is not angry. He sounds, if anything, sorry. *"If you leave, you'll be afraid of what you saw. You'll come back. Others will come. The forest can't survive that."*

He looks at the treeline. The wolves turn from the shadows and walk slowly forward, side by side, pale threads pulsing at their throats.

"I'm asking you one more time. Stay with us. You'll stop being afraid. You'll stop hurting. I promise you that much, at least."

The Grove as a Lair

On initiative count 20 (losing ties), Aldric can use one of the following **Lair Actions** — provided he is conscious and within the grove.

Lair Actions — Scaling Guidance

Designed for a **level 5–6 party**. For level 4 characters or an already intense encounter, consider dropping one or all.

If two or more characters are downed before Aldric reaches half hit points, suspend Lair Actions for the rest of the fight. The grove has made its point.

Spore Drift. Each creature in the grove not already under the Verdant Embrace must succeed on a **DC 12 Wisdom saving throw** or fall under its effects until the end of its next turn.

Grasping Roots. Roots lurch outward in a 15-foot radius around the central tree. Each creature in that area must succeed on a **DC 13 Strength saving throw** or be Restrained until the end of its next turn. A creature can free itself or another with a **DC 13 Athletics or Acrobatics check** (action).

The Bog Remembers. One Spore-Touched Wanderer rises from the bog within 60 feet of Aldric on initiative count 20 of the *following* round. Once per encounter.

Creeping Pale. Difficult Terrain spreads in a 20-foot radius around Aldric until the start of the next initiative count 20, for any creature not under the Verdant Embrace.

DM Note: Lair Actions and Tone

Grasping Roots works best early. *The Bog Remembers* lands hardest when players thought they'd cleared the fight. Use *Spore Drift* sparingly — multiple characters under the Verdant Embrace simultaneously can derail player agency.

Combat Encounter: The Grove Defends

Encounter Composition

Fungal Wolves (always present): 2 Fungal Wolves stand with Aldric from the start. They enter combat the moment Aldric does. When Aldric dies, they retreat into the bog immediately.

Standard (4 characters, levels 4–5): 2 Fungal Wolves + 1 Fungal Bear + 2 Fungal Deer + 1 Spore-Touched Wanderer

Harder (5 characters, levels 5–6): 2 Fungal Wolves + 1 Fungal Bear + 3 Fungal Deer + 2 Spore-Touched Wanderers

If Aldric enters combat: He fights to restrain and infect, not to kill — uses Spore Burst on downed characters and attempts to drag them toward the central tree.

Ending the Fight — Aldric

He falls to his knees. The fungal growth on the left side of his skull cracks and goes dark. Something leaves him — slowly, like air from a bellows.

His eyes shift — both sides of his face look the same, for a moment. Old. Tired. Profoundly human.

"Yes," he says, and his voice is different now — rougher, quieter, more afraid. *"Yes. I'm — I'm still here. Some of me."* He looks at his hands. At what has grown from them. *"How long...?"*

He doesn't finish the question.

"It doesn't hurt," he says finally, as if reassuring himself. *"At least — it doesn't hurt."*

Then he is still.

What Remains

The mycelial network does not die with Aldric's body. The grove remains contaminated. The animals will eventually wander free as the network loses coherence — this takes days. The half-buried figures beneath the roots cannot be saved.

If the characters want to truly end the grove, they can burn the central tree. This is not required, and not explicitly rewarded. It is simply something they can do.

There is no triumphant resolution here. There is only leaving.

Appendix A: New Creatures

Aldric Mourne, Infected Druid

Medium humanoid (human), chaotic neutral

Armor Class 13 (natural armor — fungal plating)
Hit Points 78 (12d8 + 24)
Speed 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
18 (+4)	10 (+0)	16 (+3)	10 (+0)	16 (+3)	14 (+2)

Saving Throws Con +5, Wis +6
Skills Nature +5, Perception +6, Medicine +4
Damage Immunities Poison
Condition Immunities Poisoned, Frightened
Senses Blindsight 30 ft. (mycelial sense), passive Perception 16
Languages Common, Druidic, Sylvan
Challenge 4 (1,100 XP)

Spore Aura. Any creature that starts its turn within 10 feet of Aldric must succeed on a DC 13 Wisdom saving throw or fall under the Verdant Embrace (see page 1). A creature already under the Verdant Embrace has disadvantage on this saving throw.

Hive Awareness. Aldric can't be surprised while any infected creature is within 300 feet of him.

Spellcasting. Aldric is a 7th-level spellcaster (Wisdom, spell save DC 14, +6 to hit). He has the following druid spells prepared — *Cantrips:* shillelagh, poison spray. *1st (4 slots):* entangle, thunderwave. *2nd (3 slots):* spike growth, barkskin. *3rd (3 slots):* call lightning, plant growth. *4th (1 slot):* blight.

Actions

Multiattack. Aldric makes two Spore Touch attacks.

Spore Touch. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +6 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 7 (1d6+4) bludgeoning damage plus 5 (2d4) poison damage. The target must succeed on a DC 13 Wisdom saving throw or fall under the Verdant Embrace.

Spore Burst (Recharge 5–6). Aldric exhales a dense cloud of spores in a 15-foot cone. Each creature in the area makes a DC 13 Wisdom saving throw. *Failure:* 14 (4d6) poison damage and the Verdant Embrace effect. *Success:* Half damage only.

Reactions

Forest Calls. When Aldric is reduced to half his hit points or fewer, 1d4 Fungal Deer or 1 Fungal Bear (DM's choice) appear at the grove's edge on initiative count 20 of the following round. Fungal Wolves are *not* triggered by this ability — they are present from the start of the encounter.

Fungal Wolf

Medium beast (infected), unaligned

Armor Class 13 (natural armor)
Hit Points 32 (5d8 + 10)
Speed 40 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
14 (+2)	15 (+2)	14 (+2)	3 (−4)	12 (+1)	6 (−2)

Skills Perception +5, Stealth +4
Damage Immunities Poison
Condition Immunities Poisoned, Frightened
Senses passive Perception 15
Challenge 1 (200 XP)

Aldric's Companion. Fungal Wolves are permanent companions to Aldric. They are present at the start of any encounter in the grove, standing at his side. When Aldric dies, they immediately disengage and retreat into the bog — they do not fight to the end.

Hive Sense. The wolf knows the location of all infected creatures within 300 feet and can't be surprised by them.

Pack Tactics. The wolf has advantage on attack rolls against a creature if at least one of the wolf's uninfected allies is adjacent to the creature and that ally isn't incapacitated.

Spore Trail. When the wolf uses its movement, the ground it passes through becomes Difficult Terrain for non-infected creatures until the end of the following round.

Actions

Bite. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +4 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 7 (2d4+2) piercing damage. The target must succeed on a DC 12 Wisdom saving throw or fall under the Verdant Embrace. If the target is Large or smaller, it must also succeed on a DC 12 Strength saving throw or be knocked prone.

Spore Howl (Recharge 5–6). The wolf releases a long, low howl carrying spores. Each non-infected creature within 20 feet that can hear it must make a DC 12 Wisdom saving throw. *Failure:* 5 (2d4) poison damage and the Verdant Embrace effect. *Success:* Half damage only.

Fungal Deer

Large beast (infected), unaligned

Armor Class 11
Hit Points 22 (4d10)
Speed 50 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
14 (+2)	10 (+0)	11 (+0)	2 (−4)	10 (+0)	5 (−3)

Skills Perception +3
Damage Immunities Poison
Condition Immunities Poisoned
Senses passive Perception 13
Challenge 1/2 (100 XP)

Hive Sense. The deer knows the location of all infected creatures within 300 feet and can't be surprised by them.

Actions

Charge. If the deer moves at least 20 feet straight toward a target and then hits it with a Ram attack on the same turn, the target takes an extra 7 (2d6) bludgeoning damage and must succeed on a DC 12 Strength saving throw or be knocked prone.

Ram. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +4 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 5 (1d6+2) bludgeoning damage.

Spore Cloud (1/Day). The deer releases spores in a 10-foot radius. Each creature must succeed on a DC 11 Constitution saving throw or have disadvantage on Constitution saving throws until the end of its next turn.

Fungal Bear

Large beast (infected), unaligned

Armor Class 13 (natural armor + fungal plating)
Hit Points 68 (8d10 + 24)
Speed 40 ft., climb 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
20 (+5)	10 (+0)	16 (+3)	2 (−4)	13 (+1)	7 (−2)

Skills Perception +3
Damage Immunities Poison
Condition Immunities Poisoned, Charmed
Senses Darkvision 60 ft., passive Perception 13
Challenge 3 (700 XP)

Infestation Aura. Any creature that takes damage from the bear must succeed on a DC 13 Constitution saving throw or be Poisoned until the end of its next turn.

Relentless (Recharges after a Short or Long Rest). If the bear takes 10 damage or less that would reduce it to 0 hit points, it is reduced to 1 hit point instead.

Actions

Multiattack. The bear makes one Bite attack and one Claws attack.

Bite. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +7 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 9 (1d8+5) piercing damage. The target must succeed on a DC 13 Constitution saving throw or take 5 (2d4) poison damage and be Grappled (escape DC 14).

Claws. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +7 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 12 (2d6+5) slashing damage.

Spore Slam (Recharge 5–6). The bear slams the ground in a 15-foot radius. Each creature makes a DC 13 Wisdom saving throw. *Failure:* 10 (3d6) poison damage and the Verdant Embrace effect. *Success:* Half damage only.

Spore-Touched Wanderer

Medium humanoid (any race), chaotic neutral

Armor Class 10
Hit Points 16 (3d8 + 3)
Speed 25 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
11 (+0)	10 (+0)	12 (+1)	3 (−4)	8 (−1)	5 (−3)

Damage Immunities Poison
Condition Immunities Poisoned, Frightened
Senses passive Perception 10
Challenge 1/4 (50 XP)

Shambling Spread. When the wanderer dies, it releases spores in a 5-foot radius. Each creature must succeed on a DC 11 Constitution saving throw or take 3 (1d6) poison damage.

Actions

Slam. *Melee Weapon Attack:* +2 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. *Hit:* 3 (1d6) bludgeoning damage plus 2 (1d4) poison damage.

Ragged Moan (1/Day). Each non-infected creature within 30 feet that can hear the wanderer must succeed on a DC 11 Wisdom saving throw or be Frightened of the wanderer until the end of its next turn.

Appendix B: DM Tools & Guidance

Running the Horror

The Verdant Embrace works best when the DM resists the urge to force a reaction. The spores don't lie to the characters — they just quietly drain the instinct to act. Let affected players sit with the knowledge that something is wrong and watch them struggle to care about it. The horror is not in what they see. It is in the silence where their alarm should be.

- Do not make Aldric a villain. He is gentle, curious, even loving — in the way that a disease can be gentle if it doesn't know what it is.
- Let the characters feel something before the fight. The combat should feel like a failure, not a triumph.
- Do not comfort the table after the final scene. Let the quiet land.

Adjusting Difficulty

- **To lower:** Remove the Fungal Bear, replace with an additional Fungal Deer. Reduce Aldric's HP to 55. Remove one Fungal Wolf.
- **To raise:** Add a second Spore-Touched Wanderer. Give Aldric Legendary Resistance (1/day).
- **For level 3 characters:** Reduce Aldric to CR 3 (drop Spore Burst, remove Multiattack). Use only Fungal Wolves and Fungal Deer.

Experience & Rewards

This adventure does not end with a treasure chest. Consider offering:

- Standard XP for all creatures defeated.
- A **Charm of the Unbowed** for each character who resisted the Verdant Embrace and still chose to enter the grove fully aware of what it was.

> **Charm of the Unbowed** *(Original Homebrew Reward)*
>
> This charm may be bestowed by a deity or cosmic force in recognition of the character's willingness to face horror without flinching. The charm lasts until used.
>
> Once, when you fail a saving throw against being Frightened or Charmed, you may choose to succeed instead. After you use this charm, it vanishes.

Hooks Into a Larger Campaign

- The mycelial network is older than any druid circle. Something woke it — or someone released it deliberately.
- The most recent half-buried figure in the grove is recognisable: a missing person the characters were hired to find.
- The grove begins to spread. Three weeks later, a nearby village reports that livestock are walking into the forest and not returning.

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